

My Journey as a Father

*Six Children, Thirty-Three Years, and What
Fatherhood Taught Me About Presence,
Responsibility, and Letting Go*

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READING SAMPLE

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About this reading sample

This reading sample contains a continuous excerpt from the beginning of *My Journey as a Father*. It is based on the edition identified on the cover. The text below is drawn from the manuscript and is not the complete book.

Excerpt length: approximately 3,905 words.

Prologue: Beginning Again in the Year I Turn Fifty-Six

There is a date circled on the calendar in our kitchen: 19 August 2026. That is when our son Andreas is due — eighteen months, almost to the week, after his sister Victoria arrived on 19 February 2025. I will still be fifty-five, a few weeks from my fifty-sixth birthday. For a stretch of months, Anna and I will have two very young children under one roof. Sleepless nights. Nappies. Feeding, carrying, comforting. Days when almost nothing goes according to plan.

I look forward to it.

People often talk about having children as though it means putting a life on hold. They list what must be sacrificed — freedom, travel, money, career, comfort, possessions — as if the ledger only runs one way. My own experience has taught me something different. Children do not have to end a dream. They change its shape. They demand more creativity, more discipline, more responsibility from us. But they also hand our lives a weight and a purpose that nothing else quite replicates.

Maybe the second car gets traded for something cheaper. Maybe a few luxuries wait a year, or five. But cars rust, houses get sold, titles expire. We leave all of it behind eventually. What continues is the family we helped build, the values we managed to pass on, and the quiet influence our lives will have on people we will never live to meet.

In the end, it is a question of values.

Choosing family does not mean giving up achievement, ambition, or growth. A career can still be built. A business can still be started. Countries can still be explored, projects still created. We are not forced to choose between a meaningful family life and a meaningful personal one. We may have to

rearrange the pieces — but we are almost always capable of more than we assume.

Too many people let other people's fears decide what is possible for them.

They are told they are too old, too young, too busy, too poor, too inexperienced, or too ambitious to have children. They are warned that parenthood will end their freedom, derail their goals, ruin their body, their sleep, their bank account. But the people offering these warnings do not live with the consequences of the choice. We do.

I believe we have to listen to ourselves first. Trust what we already know about our own strengths. Decide, deliberately, what kind of life actually matters to us — not what matters to the person giving advice at a dinner party.

Becoming a single father did not destroy my life. It forced me to roll up my sleeves, reorganise nearly everything I thought I knew about my days, and carry a level of responsibility that sometimes felt like too much. But those were also some of the most meaningful years I have lived. They taught me something simple: fear tends to shrink the moment we stop imagining every way things could go wrong and start dealing with what is actually in front of us.

A child needs food. Safety. Routines. Encouragement. Boundaries. Love. A child needs a parent who stays present when life gets complicated — not a parent who is flawless. We do not need to be perfect. We need to show up.

My six children were born across more than thirty-three years. Aleksander in 1993. Kevin in 2000. Anais in 2002. Maximilien in 2007. Victoria in 2025. Now Andreas, expected in 2026. Anna's son, Rocky, is part of our blended family too. It is an unusual position — being the father of adult children, teenagers, a toddler, and a newborn, all within the same stretch of years.

Each of them has met a different version of me.

My older children knew a younger father — building businesses, working long hours, still trying to understand adulthood while raising a family at the same time. Kevin knew me as a single father juggling daily responsibility with a job that put me on more than fifty flights a year. Maximilien knew a father determined not to accept the low expectations other people had already decided to place on him. Victoria and Andreas will know an older father living in Spain, surrounded by olive trees and Mediterranean light, carrying decades of experience I simply did not have when my first children were born.

Experience does not mean I now have all the answers.

It means I understand, finally, the importance of the questions.

In October 2025, we moved from Høvik in Norway to Benidorm, on Spain's Costa Blanca. It keeps us close to our olive farm in Biar while giving the children schools, people, activity, beaches, and a city that stays alive all year. For now, it works.

Anna and I are still deciding whether Victoria and Andreas should ultimately grow up closer to the olive farm in Biar or in the life we have built in Benidorm. The farm offers land, work, nature, and freedom; the city offers friends, schools, activity, and independence as they grow. We are letting the question remain open. Houses can be sold, rebuilt, or replaced. Childhood cannot.

This book is the record of the choices, mistakes, losses, victories, and unexpected new beginnings that shaped me as a father. It is also an invitation — to think, alongside me, about what actually matters.

I am proud of the life I have lived, including the parts that hurt. I have no interest in presenting myself as a perfect

father. I have made mistakes. I have been through divorce, lost relationships, struggled with health and money, and gone through stretches when I had no idea how any of it would turn out.

But I kept going.

In the year I turn fifty-six, with two small children and a family that now spans several generations, I do not feel like my most important years are behind me.

In many ways, I am only just getting started.

PART I · The Father I Became

The experiences that formed the father before the children arrived.

Chapter 1: Before I Became the Father I Am Today

Frank came home with a bruise across his cheek and a story about a boy who had knocked him down. I did not ask many questions. I walked straight over, put the boy on the ground, and made sure he understood he would never touch my brother again.

I am not telling this story because fighting was the right way to solve it. As an adult, and later as a father, I would teach a child to find a different response — to speak first, to walk away, to bring in someone older. But the memory has stayed with me for a reason. It shows something that has run through my whole life: when someone I love is vulnerable, my first instinct is to step in.

That instinct did not start with fatherhood. It started years earlier, in a house full of brothers and a street full of children, where looking after other people was simply something you

did. No one announced it. No one asked permission. You just went.

I was born on 12 October 1970 in Jessheim, in Akershus, Norway. My parents lived in Nannestad, and I spent roughly the first ten years of my life there, in a newly built detached house on a street crowded with kids close to my own age. There was always someone to play with, and always something to do.

Our childhood happened mostly outdoors.

We disappeared into the forest for entire afternoons. We built shelters from branches, carved bows and spears, and told ourselves we were warriors surviving in the wild. We made slingshots out of nothing, raced sledges down the steepest hills we could find, skied, and invented games from whatever the forest happened to give us that day. Nobody organised our entertainment. The forest, the snow, and each other were enough.

I was a big kid, physically strong for my age, and I fell naturally into the role of protector — of my friends, and especially of my siblings. Frank was the one who needed defending that day. He would not be the last person I stepped in for.

The Morning My Mother Trusted Me

One memory from that childhood still stands sharper than almost any other.

My father was painting the house when he fell from the ladder. He ended up in hospital with severe back and sciatic pain. At the time he ran the cafeteria at the Electrolux factory, and a business like that does not simply pause while its owner heals.

So my mother took over his work.

She had to leave the house by around 5:30 every morning. My younger brother, Kai, was three years old, and somebody had to get him up, dressed, fed, and out the door.

I was nine.

I was the middle son, not the oldest, but my mother handed that job to me. Every morning I woke Kai, changed him, dressed him, and walked him to his childminder. Then I went home, woke my older brother, made food for school, and walked roughly five kilometres to my own classroom.

Looking back, that is a lot to put on a nine-year-old. I do not remember it that way. I remember feeling proud.

My mother chose me because she trusted me.

She has told me many times since — she knew she could count on me. I did not wander off, forget the plan, or put my own comfort first. I did the job because someone needed me to.

That morning shaped something in me that never really left.

Responsibility was not handed to me as a punishment. It arrived as proof that I was trusted. Through her actions, my mother was telling me something no lecture could have: that I was capable, dependable, and necessary to this family.

Children tend to grow into the size of the expectations we place on them. Give them a task that matters, and trust them to do it, and you are not just getting the dishes washed or the toddler dressed. You are handing them a piece of who they will become.

My mother's trust taught me to see myself as someone people could rely on.

Decades later, when life asked me to become a single father, to hold down demanding jobs, to go through a divorce, and to fight for children who needed someone in their corner, that nine-year-old was still in there somewhere.

Someone depended on me.

So I did what needed to be done.

My Father, Inge

My father, Inge, was born on 1 June 1940. He was kind, considerate, and endlessly helpful — the kind of man neighbours ask for favours because they know he will say yes. I can count on one hand the times I saw him truly angry. He worked hard, changed jobs more than once, and almost certainly carried worries we children never heard about.

He kept those to himself.

Instead, he took us fishing. He found small ways to make an ordinary Saturday feel like an event. He belonged to a generation of men who were never taught to put feelings into words, or into a hug. My first real embrace from him came after I turned nineteen.

That was not because the feeling was not there. It was because many men of his generation had learned that a father shows love through work and responsibility and quiet acts of service — not through saying it out loud.

As he aged, showing emotion got easier for him. In his last years I saw more clearly the soft, sensitive man who had been standing behind all those habits the whole time.

My father died on 17 March 2025.

In his final three years his body simply stopped cooperating. Heart, lungs, kidneys, liver — one after another, they weakened. Eventually an infection found the openings his weakened organs left behind.

Still, he barely complained.

He had never been a man who rushed to the doctor, or wanted to trouble anyone with his own pain. Even while he

was suffering, his instinct was to avoid becoming a burden to the people around him.

There is a kind of strength in that. There is also a warning worth taking seriously. We should not make the people who love us guess when we are struggling. Asking for help is not weakness. Sometimes protecting the people who love us means letting them see exactly what is happening — so they can actually help.

I am endlessly grateful that Inge was my father.

From him I learned kindness, helpfulness, endurance, and the discipline of building good memories for your children even when the rest of your life is hard. I also learned that love needs to be shown, not just felt privately and assumed.

That my first hug from him came so late shaped how I raised my own children. I wanted mine to hear it and feel it, not have to reconstruct it later from clues. Children should not need to decode love from practical gestures alone. They should be told. They should be held.

My father did the best he could with the tools his generation had given him. My job was never to judge him for what he had not been taught. It was to take the good he gave me and carry it one step further.

My Mother, Reidun

My mother, Reidun, was born on 6 September 1947. Ours has always been an unusually close relationship.

I was probably her favourite, though families rarely say such things out loud. We spent enormous amounts of time together. I went with her to visit her parents, her friends — I started drinking coffee young simply because I wanted a seat at the table where the real conversations happened.

I was not the child sent off to play whenever adults started talking. I was included in the room.

My mother and I have always told each other the truth. We share almost everything, and there has always been an ease between us — she understood me, and I understood her.

Her trust was one of the load-bearing walls of my childhood.

She did not simply tell me I was responsible. She proved it by handing me real responsibility. She treated me like someone capable of understanding a situation and doing something useful about it.

That shaped how I later raised my own children. I have never believed in shielding kids from every task, every expectation, every hard thing. They need security, yes. But they also need the chance to discover, for themselves, that they are useful and capable.

When we do everything for a child, we think we are showing love. Sometimes what we are actually doing is stealing from them the pride of being trusted.

A Marriage That Lasted

My parents were married for nearly six decades. I could not tell you the exact number of years, but they spent almost their whole adult lives side by side.

They argued, as couples do. They were different people with different opinions, and life was not always smooth between them. But there was never violence in our home, never conflict that frightened us as children. Underneath the disagreements, they loved each other.

Late in life, they spent four years in Spain.

I believe those were among the happiest years of their marriage. They walked. They ate well. They took photographs, explored new places, sat in the sun, and built memories that

had nothing to do with the routines they had known their whole lives in Norway. Spain gave them energy, and it gave them a shared, ordinary daily life that felt new again.

They both said, more than once, that they wished they had made the move sooner.

Their years there ended abruptly. My mother suffered a heart attack mid-flight on the way back to Norway. By luck, two doctors happened to be on board and were able to help her. She later had a pacemaker fitted — the same pacemaker that would go on to save her life through further cardiac arrests.

After that, she could no longer fly, and my parents moved back to Norway for good.

Life slowly returned to the old routines. They moved less, sat indoors more, shared fewer new experiences. And with less movement, less sunlight, less variety, the old irritations found their way back in more easily than before.

Love is essential. It is not, on its own, enough. Couples need shared projects, movement, new conversations, new memories — not just a long shared history to draw on. It is tempting to believe a strong relationship can run forever on what has already been built. But relationships need new fuel too, not just old foundations.

Watching my parents, I came to associate those Spanish years with more movement, variety, shared experiences, and a lighter daily rhythm. I cannot separate cause from memory well enough to claim the environment produced their health or happiness. What I can say is that those years shaped my own idea of the life I later wanted to build.

A Child Who Enjoyed Learning

I liked school. I liked learning.

I was polite, well-behaved, rarely in trouble, and I had plenty of friends — but I was also ambitious in a way that stood out. Even as a boy I said out loud that one day I would sit in an office and run something.

That was the future I pictured for myself, and in one form or another, I got there.

My education did not stop when compulsory school ended. Over the years that followed, I kept going — further education, training programmes, courses, professional development, one after another. I have always been curious about how things work, and how knowledge actually gets used once you leave the classroom.

Learning, for me, was never confined to certificates on a wall. It is closer to a way of moving through life. When something does not make sense to me, my instinct is to go find out why.

That instinct mattered later, as a father. When one of my children ran into difficulty, I did not want to settle for the first explanation handed to me. I wanted to understand the actual problem, look at the alternatives, and find out what could still be done.

A Lifelong Student

My formal education kept branching out long after school finished. I studied commerce and office administration, including casework and legal studies, then travel and tourism. Later came EDB-skolen, the IT Academy, BI Norwegian Business School, and Ecademy.

At Idefagskolen in Tønsberg I completed a year in photography and a year in media design. I also spent four years studying astrology and three years studying White Time healing, on top of a long list of professional courses and certifications.

On paper, these subjects look unrelated. They are not, not really — they reflect how my mind works. I have always wanted to understand systems: how people think, how communication actually lands, how creativity and business fit together, how human beings construct the beliefs they use to make sense of their lives.

That patchwork education let me move between very different roles over the years: business owner, accountant, manager, technology adviser, Key Account Manager, photographer, media designer, trainer, property adviser, speaker, author. I taught Google AdWords to hospitals in northern Norway. I built web solutions for public institutions, organisations, and large companies.

I do not think education only counts when a qualification leads straight to a job title. Learning changes how many solutions you are able to see in the first place. As a father, it let me explain a school subject three different ways until one of them landed, question a system without losing my temper, build flexible work around my children's needs, and show them that development does not stop the day school ends.

Learning the Value of Work at Thirteen

I started earning my own money at thirteen.

Every afternoon after school, for around two hours, I delivered newspapers. Rain, ice, wind — the papers went out regardless. That taught me early that work is not something you do only when it is convenient or enjoyable. Someone was waiting for that paper. Finishing the job was my responsibility, full stop.

On weekends, I worked at the same place as my mother — a company that prepared meals for airline passengers. My job was the dishwashing area: the trays, plates, cutlery, and kitchen equipment that came back in enormous quantities once the food had gone out and been served.

The work was repetitive and hard on the hands. I did not mind it.

By that age I had already started associating work with independence. Earning money gave me options, and a kind of quiet security. I did not spend everything I made. I saved what I could and watched the number in my bank account climb, slowly, month after month.

By the time I reached adulthood, that habit had built up a substantial amount of savings — not from one big decision, but from years of small ones.

That shaped how I think about money to this day. Financial security is almost never built by a single dramatic move. It is built through hundreds of small ones: showing up, finishing the task, saying no to something you do not need, saving what is left, and repeating that for years.

The money mattered. The habits mattered more.

Starting work at thirteen taught me discipline, patience, and a certain respect for the effort sitting behind everything we buy without thinking about it. It also gave me pride — I knew the money in my account had not been handed to me. I had earned it on cold afternoons with a bag of papers cutting into my shoulder, and in a steaming dish room with my hands red from hot water. That kind of pride does not fade. It sits underneath everything else you build later — the jobs that come after, the decisions you make, the way you treat people who are doing the unglamorous, repetitive work that keeps things running. I have never forgotten what it feels like to be the one washing the trays while someone else eats the meal.

Looking back, I do not think the specific jobs mattered nearly as much as the pattern they set. Deliver the paper, no matter the weather. Wash the tray, no matter how many are left in the stack. Show up again next week, even though nothing about the work itself is exciting. That pattern,

repeated often enough, stops being something you force yourself to do and becomes simply who you are. By the time other people my age were beginning to think about their first jobs, I already had years of practice behind me — not glamorous years, but formative ones.

I think a lot of what people call "work ethic" is really just early exposure. You cannot instill in someone the value of finishing a job if they have never had to finish one that mattered to somebody else. The customer expecting their newspaper did not care whether I felt like riding my bike that day. The airline passenger eating off that tray did not know or care that a thirteen-year-old had scrubbed it clean an hour earlier. That invisibility of the work is, in a strange way, part of what made it valuable to me. I was not doing it for recognition. I was doing it because it needed to be done, and because I had said I would do it.

That is, I think, the real inheritance of those early years — not the money I saved, though that mattered too, but the quiet understanding that competence and reliability are built in private, long before anyone is watching, in the small, unglamorous tasks nobody remembers you doing.

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